STUDY BOOKLET · 11 NOVEMBER 2026 · 1 KISLEV 5787

We Have Surely Seen: The Treaty at Beersheba

An excerpt for LinkedIn: the introduction and Chapter Three, “Seeing, We Have Seen” (Bereishis 26:28–29). The full study booklet runs to 94 pages.

ראו ראינו כי היה ה' עמך

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren

We Have Surely Seen: The Treaty at Beersheba

An excerpt for LinkedIn: the introduction and Chapter Three, "Seeing, We Have Seen" (Bereishis 26:28–29). The full study booklet runs to 94 pages.

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren

Prepared on Wednesday, 11 November 2026 (1 Kislev 5787, the second day of Rosh Chodesh Kislev), Jerusalem, in the week of Parashas Toldos.
Not for sale. For study at the table, in the beis midrash and at home.

Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI

A note on sources

Every Hebrew quotation in this booklet was cut directly from the text as opened on Sefaria on 11 November 2026, with vowels and cantillation removed. Verses from Tanach are given in the English of *Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures* (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), as published on Sefaria. Other sources are given in the published English translations named beside them: Rashi in the translation of Rosenbaum and Silbermann, the Ramban in the translation of Rabbi Charles Chavel, the Sforno, Radak and Or HaChaim in the translations of Rabbi Eliyahu Munk, the Rambam in the translation of Rabbi Eliyahu Touger, the Talmud in the William Davidson edition, the Midrash Rabbah in the Sefaria translation, Rashi on Malachi in the Judaica Press translation, and the Chofetz Chaim in the Silverstein translation. The *Hayom Yom* and the Tanya are quoted in the Kehot translation as published on Chabad.org. Where no published translation was available, the translation is mine and is marked as a working translation. The edition used for each text is listed in the Bibliography.

Divine Names. In English this booklet writes G-d, L-rd and Hashem, including inside quoted translations. In Hebrew the Tetragrammaton and the short two-letter Name are printed as ה', and the name Elokim as אלקים. No Divine Name is printed in full.

Current events. A few chapters mention events of the week of 10 November 2026: the swearing-in of the twenty-sixth Knesset, the vote on its Speaker set for 17 November 2026, a ruling of an Egyptian court, and the death of Jarosława Lewicka. Each is taken from a named report, listed in the Bibliography. Where only one report was opened for a detail, the Bibliography says so. The booklet makes no prediction about any vote and argues for no party.

Care in speech. The commentators on these verses speak of a king who wronged Yitzchak. This booklet keeps to their words and applies them to no living person, party or government.

Contents

Introduction. The Fourth Well 5

Seven verses, the portions of the day, and the offering for a diminished moon

Chapter Three. Seeing, We Have Seen 8

Bereishis 26:28–29: two generations of seeing, two stories of one past, and the heron's peace

Glossary 17

Bibliography 19

INTRODUCTION

The Fourth Well

Seven verses, the portions of the day, and the offering for a diminished moon

Yitzchak goes up to Beersheba and the king who sent him away comes after him. This introduction sets out the daily portions of 1 Kislev 5787 that form the spine of the booklet, reads the new-moon offering of Rosh Chodesh, and points to the companion booklets of the month.

The fourth well

The Torah reading for Wednesday, 11 November 2026, the first of Kislev 5787, is seven verses long. Yitzchak has dug three wells in the valley of Gerar. He named the first two after the quarrels they caused, Esek and Sitnah, and the third, which no one fought over, Rechovos. Now he goes up to Beersheba. There G-d appears to him at night, he builds an altar, pitches a tent, and his servants begin a fourth well. Before the well is finished, the king who sent him away arrives with his councilor and his general, asking for a treaty.

Seven verses, and almost every large question a people faces is in them. How do you hold your ground when you have been pushed out? Can a covenant begin with a grievance? What does a former adversary see that makes him come to your tent? What do the two sides owe each other once they have sworn?

This booklet reads those seven verses slowly, with Rashi and the commentators who came after him, and then follows their questions into the rest of the day's learning and the days around it.

The day's portions

The spine of the booklet is the daily learning for 1 Kislev 5787, the second day of Rosh Chodesh Kislev:

- **Chumash:** Parashas Toldos, fourth portion, Bereishis 26:23–29, with Rashi.
- **Hayom Yom:** 1 Kislev, on Rabbi Yekusiel Liepler, a chassid of the Alter Rebbe, who at times davened Shacharis, Mincha and Maariv one after the other, with no time between them.

- **Daf Yomi:** Bechoros 54, on the tithe of animals and what makes separate flocks into one count.
- **Tehillim:** chapters 1–9, the first day of the monthly cycle.
- **Rambam:** Hilchos Sheluchin veShutfin, the Laws of Agents and Partners, chapters 2–4, and Hilchos Maachalos Asuros, the Laws of Forbidden Foods, chapter 1.
- **Chofetz Chaim:** Hilchos Lashon Hara 7:5–7:6, on when a listener may believe what he hears.

Part One reads the portions themselves. Chapters One to Three walk through the seven verses of Toldos. Chapter Four reads the Hayom Yom, with a short bridge through the first psalms of the month. Chapter Five reads the Mishnah and Gemara of Bechoros 54. Part Two follows four themes that grow out of the portions: partnership and agency (Chapter Six), the righteous of the nations (Chapter Seven), memory and the laws of speech (Chapter Eight), and the difference between outward signs and inner nature (Chapter Nine).

The offering for a diminished moon

The day is Rosh Chodesh, and the Torah reading for Rosh Chodesh is the passage of the new-moon offerings.

> ובראשי חדשיכם תקריבו עלה לה' פרים בני־בקר שנים ואיל אחד כבשים בני־שנה שבעה תמימם

On your new moons you shall present a burnt offering to the L-RD: two bulls of the herd, one ram, and seven yearling lambs, without blemish. (JPS)

Bamidbar 28:11

At the end of the list comes one more animal.

> ושעיר עזים אחד לחטאת לה' על־עלת התמיד יעשה ונסכו

And there shall be one goat as a sin offering to the L-RD, to be offered in addition to the regular burnt offering and its libation. (JPS)

Bamidbar 28:15

Rashi brings the reason given in the Aggadah.

> ומדרשו באגדה, אמר הקב"ה הביאו כפרה עלי על שמעטתי את הירח

But its Aggadic explanation is as follows: The Holy One, blessed be He, said, "Bring an atonement offering for My sake, because I diminished the size of the Moon" (Rosenbaum–Silbermann)

Rashi on Bamidbar 28:15

The Gemara in Chullin tells the story at length. The sun and moon were created equal. The moon complained that two kings cannot share one crown, and was told to make herself smaller. Every Rosh Chodesh, the goat of the new moon recalls that one party to a shared rule gave up part of its light, and that the giving up was not forgotten.

That is a good doorway into a booklet about treaties and partnerships. Every arrangement between two parties asks one of them, sometimes both, to be a little smaller than it could be. The Torah does not pretend the cost is nothing. It marks it, every month, with an offering.

How to use this booklet

Each chapter opens with a short summary and closes with questions for the table. The Hebrew of every source is printed beside its English, so a pair of learners can check the translation against the original. Where a published translation exists, it is used and named; where none was available, the translation is mine and is marked as a working translation. The appendices give the full Hebrew and English of Bereishis 26, of the first treaty at Beersheba in Bereishis 21, of the Rosh Chodesh reading and of the haftarah of Toldos, and the Hebrew of Rashi and other commentators on the seven verses, of Bechoros 54, of the day's chapters of Rambam, and of the day's principle of the Chofetz Chaim.

Companions

This booklet stands beside five others prepared for Rosh Chodesh Kislev 5787. *Kislev: The Architecture of Completion* treats the month as a whole. *Tehillim 1–9: The First Day* reads the psalms of the monthly cycle in full, so this booklet gives them only a short bridge in Chapter Four. *Tehillim 94: The Song of the Fourth Day*, *Tehillim 25: To You I Lift My Soul* and *Tehillim 144: Who Trains My Hands* read other psalms of the season. Where a theme here has been treated there, I point to it rather than repeat it.

CHAPTER THREE

Seeing, We Have Seen

Bereishis 26:28–29: two generations of seeing, two stories of one past, and the heron's peace

The delegation explains its visit. This chapter reads Rashi and the Midrash on what they saw in father and son, the Or HaChaim on the doubled verb, the Sforno and the Malbim on recognition instead of fear, the Ramban on the broken first oath, the Radak and the Midrash on the king's version of events, and Rabbi Yehoshua ben Chananyah's parable of the lion and the heron.

Seeing, we have seen

> ויאמרו ראו ראינו כי־היה ה' עמך ונאמר תהי נא אלה בינותינו בינינו ובינך ונכרתה ברית עמך אם־תעשה עמנו רעה כאשר לא נגענוך וכאשר עשינו עמך רק־טוב ונשלחך בשלום אתה עתה ברוך ה'
>
> *And they said, "We now see plainly that the L-RD has been with you, and we thought: Let there be a sworn treaty between our two parties, between you and us. Let us make a pact with you that you will not do us harm, just as we have not molested you but have always dealt kindly with you and sent you away in peace. From now on, be you blessed of the L-RD!" (JPS)*
>
> Bereishis 26:28–29

The king's answer begins with a doubled verb, *ra'o ra'inu*, literally *seeing, we have seen*. JPS renders it "We now see plainly." Rashi reads the doubling as two acts of seeing.

> ראו ראינו. ראינו באביך, ראינו בך
>
> ראו ראינו *WE SAW PLAINLY (literally, seeing we have seen) — We saw it in the case of your father and we see it in the case of yourself (Genesis Rabbah 64:10). (Rosenbaum–Silbermann)*
>
> Rashi on Bereishis 26:28

The Midrash that Rashi cites says the same at more length.

> ויאמרו ראו ראינו (בראשית כו, כח), ראינו מעשיך ומעשה אבותיך, (בראשית כו, כח): ונאמר תהי נא אלה אם תעשה עמנו וגו', רק מעוט שלא עשו עמו טובה שלמה

"They said: We saw" – we have seen your actions and the actions of your fathers. "Let there now be an oath…if you will do us [no harm…and just as we have done only [rak] good with you]" – rak is restrictive, as they did not perform absolute good with him. (Sefaria Midrash Rabbah)

Bereishis Rabbah 64:10

The delegation says "we have seen your actions and the actions of your fathers." It has not come because of one good harvest. They have watched two generations. They saw it with Avraham, who was blessed wherever he went and with whom the first Avimelech made a treaty. Now they have seen it again with Yitzchak, who reaped a hundredfold in a year of famine and found water wherever he dug. One case might be luck. Two cases, across two generations, are a pattern.

The Or HaChaim asks why the Torah needed the doubled word at all.

> ויאמרו ראו ראינו וגו'. צריך לדעת למה כפל לומר "ראו" וגו', גם שאר הדקדוקים

Why did Avimelech and company repeat: "we have seen, seen?" There are also other nuances in their remarks which we need to analyse. (Munk)

Or HaChaim on Bereishis 26:28

His answer, at length, is that the king was answering every possible meaning of Yitzchak's question. If Yitzchak meant *you already have my father's oath, so why do you need mine?,* the answer is that they have seen that his father's oath now lives through him. If he meant *why come to me and not to my older brother Yishmael?,* the answer is that they have seen that the L-rd is with him, and so he is the heir of the promises. If he meant *you showed me hatred,* the answer is that a man with whom G-d is present is protected and blessed wherever he goes, so sending him away did him no harm. Each "seeing" answers a different charge.

Not from fear

Why does a king need a treaty with a man who has no army? The Sforno answers in one line.

> כי היה ה' עמך. ולא מיראתנו ממך נכרות אתך ברית

כי היה ה' עמך *, we do not want to make a deal with you because we are afraid of you, but because G-d is on your side. (Munk)*

Sforno on Bereishis 26:28

The Sforno's Avimelech insists that he has not come out of fear. He has come because he recognizes something. That may be the most flattering way to tell the story, and the Ramban, as we will see, is less sure. But the Sforno's reading gives weight to the words "We now see plainly." A treaty built on recognition is stronger than one built on fear, because fear ends when the danger ends, while recognition can grow.

The Malbim goes deeper into what exactly the king saw.

ויאמרו ראו ראינו. ר"ל תחלה חשבנו שהצלחתך היא מצד הארץ ואתה ממעט את השפע שלנו, אבל עתה ראינו שהצלחתך היא מצד כי היה ה' עמך,וזה אינו מגרע השפע שלנו, נהפוך הוא, שע"י השגחת ה' וברכתו עליך נתברך גם אנחנו, וע"כ ונאמר תהי נא אלה בינותינו, ר"ל שאנחנו יש בינותינו אלה וכריתת ברית, היינו בין אבימלך ואחוזת מרעהו ופיכול שהיו כאחים יחדו, ורוצה אני שאלה הזאת תהיה גם ביני ובינך שגם אתה תהיה בכורתי ברית אחים יחדו, או שר"ל שאלה כבר יש בינותינו מן אברהם ואבימלך שהיה האלה גם על זרעם תתחדש ביני ובינך לחדש את האלה והברית שנית, ועז"א אתה עתה ברוך ה', ר"ל שראינו שטעינו מה שחשבנו שאתה נתעשרת מארצנו ומגרע את השפע שלנו, שהלא ראינו שאתה גם עתה שאינך ביניינו, אתה ברוך ה' בפ"ע ואינך צריך אל ארצנו

> *At first we thought that your success came from the land, and that you were diminishing our own abundance. But now we have seen that your success comes because the L-rd was with you, and that does not take away from our abundance. On the contrary: through the L-rd's providence and His blessing upon you, we too have been blessed. Therefore "we said: let there be an oath between us." Among ourselves there is an oath and a covenant, between Avimelech, Achuzzas his councilor and Pichol, who are like brothers together, and I want this oath to be between me and you as well, so that you too will be with me in a covenant of brothers together. Or he means: an oath already exists between us from Avraham and Avimelech, for the oath was also on their descendants; let it be renewed between me and you. And so he says, "you are now blessed of the L-rd": we have seen that we were mistaken when we thought you grew rich from our land and diminished our abundance, for we see that now too, when you are no longer among us, you are blessed of the L-rd on your own, and you have no need of our land. (working translation)*
>
> Malbim on Bereishis 26:28

This is one of the most practical comments in the chapter. The people of Gerar had thought in terms of a fixed amount. If Yitzchak was getting rich in their land, he must be taking something from them. His blessing was their loss. So they sent him away. Then they watched him prosper in Beersheba, outside their land, and they understood that his blessing had never come out of their share. Worse, or better, they realized that while he was among them, they had been blessed through him.

The Malbim's reading is a picture of how enmity often begins and how it can end. It begins with the belief that another's success must be my loss. It can end when I see that the other's blessing has its own source, and that being near it may bless me too.

The oath that was already there

> תהי נא אלה בינותינו וגו'. האלה אשר בינותינו מימי אביך תהי גם עתה בינינו וביניך
>
> *means LET THE OATH that has existed BETWEEN US since the days of your father CONTINUE NOW BETWEEN US AND YOU. (Rosenbaum–Silbermann)*
>
> Rashi on Bereishis 26:28

Rashi hears a double phrase in the verse: "between our two parties, between you and us." The first "between us" is the oath that already exists, from the days of Avraham. The second is the oath between us and you, now. Avimelech is not asking for something new. He is asking for something old to continue.

The Ramban is more suspicious, and his reading explains why the king came in such a hurry.

> וענין היראה הזאת אשר פחדו ממנו אינו נראה שירא מלך פלשתים שלא יבא עליו יצחק למלחמה, אבל הבטיחם אברהם לו ולנינו ולנכדו (בראשית כ"א:כ"ג), ועתה אמרו בלבם בעבור שהפרנו אנחנו את בריתנו עם יצחק ושלחנוהו מעלינו
>
> *The reason for their being fearful of him could hardly have been the apprehension of the king of the Philistines lest Isaac come to war against him. Instead, it was because Abraham had promised them a covenant, "to him, to his son, and his son's son," and now they thought, "Since we annulled our covenant with Isaac and sent him away from us, (Chavel)*
>
> Ramban on Bereishis 26:29

> ולכן עשו עמו ברית חדשה, והתנצלו לאמר לו שלא הפרו הברית הראשונה, שלא עשו עמו רק טוב
>
> *This was why they made a new covenant with him, excusing themselves by telling him that they did not annul the first covenant, since they have done him nothing but good. (Chavel)*
>
> Ramban on Bereishis 26:29

In the Ramban's reading, the king's fear was not of an army. It was of a broken treaty. Avraham had promised peace to the king, his son and his grandson. Then Gerar sent Avraham's son away. The king reasoned that if he had broken his side, Yitzchak might consider himself free of his, and Yitzchak's descendants might one day drive out the king's. So he came quickly to make a new covenant, and to explain that the first one had never been broken, since, as the Ramban puts it, "they have done him nothing but good."

Two stories of one past

Now the two sides tell the same history. Yitzchak said that they "have been hostile to me and have driven me away from you." The delegation says they "have not molested you but have always dealt kindly with you and sent you away in peace." Rashi on the king's words shows how they understood their own conduct.

> לא נגענוך. כשאמרנו לך לך מעמנו
>
> לא נגענוך *WE HAVE NOT TOUCHED THEE when we said to you "Go from us". (Rosenbaum–Silbermann)*
>
> Rashi on Bereishis 26:29

They did not touch him; they only spoke, "when we said to you" to go. In their telling, sending him away was not harm. They never touched him. They only asked him to leave.

The Radak gives their account its most generous form.

> אתה עתה ברוך ה'. כי ה' מצליחך בכל דרכיך ותוכל לעשות לנו רעה אם תרצה, אבל לא תהיה דרך טובה, כי אנחנו לא עשינו עמך רק טוב ולא גרשנוך מעמנו דרך קלון אלא דרך כבוד, שלחנוך בשלום, ובעבור קנאת פלשתים אמרנו לך מה שאמרנו כדי שלא יגעו בך מרב קנאתם
>
> *seeing that G-d has made you so successful you are now in a position to do us harm if you so desire. This would not be appropriate seeing that we have throughout treated you in a friendly manner while we had been in a position to inflict harm upon you. Even when we expelled you we did so in a manner that did not make you suffer an indignity. When we told you to leave, this was only on account of the envy your success had aroused among the Philistine man in the street. We wanted to insure that they would not allow their envy of you to provoke them into harming you. (Munk)*
>
> Radak on Bereishis 26:29

The Radak's Avimelech says that the expulsion was a kindness. The people of Gerar were jealous, and jealousy can turn violent. By sending Yitzchak away with honor, before anyone laid a hand on him, the king protected him.

The Midrash will not let the king's version stand unexamined. It notices one small word.

The king says they did *rak tov*, only good. The Midrash says that "rak is restrictive, as they did not perform absolute good with him." They did good, but not complete good. They did not harm him, but they did not treat him as a friend either. The king's account is not a lie. It is partial.

The Torah does not stop the story to decide between the two accounts. It does not ask Yitzchak to agree that being sent away was kindness, and it does not ask the king to

confess that it was harm. What both sides can agree on is what they have seen: that the L-rd was with Yitzchak, in his father's days and in his own. The treaty rests on that.

The Chofetz Chaim, in the passage studied on 11 November 2026, gives a rule for hearing such accounts.

> ואם אחד בא אצלו ומספר לו את ענייניו ובתוך ספורו ספר לו איזה דבר, שהוא גנות לעצמו ולחברו, אינו מתר להאמינו, רק על עצמו (יא) ולא על חברו
>
> *And if one comes to him and tells him of his affairs, and includes something demeaning both to himself and to his friend, he is permitted to believe only what applies to himself and not what applies to his friend. (Silverstein)*
>
> Chofetz Chaim, Hilchos Lashon Hara 7:6

A person telling his own story may be believed about himself, but not about the other person in it. Yitzchak, hearing the king's history, does not have to accept the king's version of what Yitzchak felt or deserved. But he also need not condemn the king on the strength of his own pain. He can make a treaty on what both of them saw.

Do us no harm

> אתה. גם אתה עשה לנו כמו כן
>
> אתה *THOU — thou, also, do with us in a like manner. (Rosenbaum–Silbermann)*
>
> Rashi on Bereishis 26:29

Rashi reads the last word as a request: "thou, also, do with us in a like manner." The king asks for what he says he gave: no harm. The weaker party in the room is no longer the man without an army. It is the king, who has seen that Yitzchak's blessing does not depend on him, and who fears what Yitzchak's descendants might do.

The Midrash brings a story from a much later age that shows how thin such a peace can be.

בימי רבי יהושע בן חנניה גזרה מלכות הרשעה שיבנה בית המקדש, הושיבו פפוס ולוליאנוס טרפיזין מעכו עד אנטוכיא והיו מספקין לעולי גולה כסף וזהב וכל צרכם. אזלין אלין כותאי ואמרין [עי' (עזרא ד, יב יג)]: ידיע להוי למלכא דהדין קרתא מרדתא תתבנא ושוריא ישתכללון מנדה בלו והלך לא יתנון. מנדה, זו מדת הארץ. בלו, זו פרובגירון. והלך, אנגרוטינה. ואמר להון מה נעביד וגזרית, אמרין ליה שלח ואמר להון או ישנון יתיה מאתריה, או יוספון עליה חמש אמין, או יבצרון מניה חמש אמין, מן גרמיהון אינון חזרין בהון. והון קהליא מצתין בהדא בקעתא דבית רמון, כיון דאתון כתיבא שרון בכיין. בעיין לממרד על מלכותא, אמרין יעול חד בר נש חכימא וישדך צבורא, אמרין יעול רבי יהושע בן חנניא דהוא אסכולוסטקיא דאורייתא. עאל ודרש ארי טרף טרף ועמד עצם בגרונו, אמר כל דאתי מפיק ליה אנא יהיב ליה אגריה, אתא הדין קורא מצראה דמקוריה אריך, יהיב מקוריה ואפקיה, אמר ליה הב לי אגרי, אמר ליה זיל תהא מלגלג ואומר דעילת לפומא דאריה בשלם ונפקת בשלם, כך דיינו שנכנסנו לאמה זו בשלום ויצאנו בשלום

In the days of Rabbi Yehoshua ben Ḥananya, the evil empire decreed that the Temple should be constructed. Papus and Lulyanus set tables from Akko to Antioch, and they provided those ascending from the exile with silver and gold, and all their needs. The Samaritans went and said: "Let it be known to the king…that [if] this rebellious city is built, and its walls finished, they will not pay minda, belo, or halakh" (Ezra 4:12–13) – minda is property tax, belo is poll tax, and halakh is head tax. He said to them: 'What can I do, I issued a decree.' They said to him: 'Send and say to them: Either move it from its place, or add five cubits to it, or subtract five cubits from it, and they will relent on their own.' The assembly of Israel were gathered together in the Beit Rimon valley. When those missives arrived, they began weeping. They wanted to rebel against the empire. They said: 'Let one Sage enter and calm the assembly.' They said: 'Let Rabbi Yehoshua ben Ḥananya, who is the greatest Torah scholar, enter.' He entered and expounded: 'A lion mauled prey and a bone was stuck in its throat. He [the lion] said: Anyone who extracts it, I will give him a reward. An Egyptian heron with a long beak inserted its beak and extracted it. It said to it [the lion]: Give me my reward. It [the lion] said to it: Go, boast, and say that you entered the mouth of a lion in peace and emerged in peace. So, it is sufficient that we entered into dealings with this nation in peace, and emerged in peace.' (Sefaria Midrash Rabbah)

Bereishis Rabbah 64:10

The lion's reward to the heron was the heron's own life: you put your head in my mouth and took it out in peace. Rabbi Yehoshua ben Chananyah told the people, gathered in grief and ready to rebel, that sometimes a treaty with a great power gives no more than that. It is enough to have entered in peace and come out in peace. The Midrash sets this story beside Avimelech's *rak*, only good, because it knows that many treaties are of this kind. They do not make friends. They make room to live.

A feast, an oath, and water

The Torah tells us how the meeting ended.

> ויעש להם משתה ויאכלו וישתו וישכימו בבקר וישבעו איש לאחיו וישלחם יצחק וילכו מאתו בשלום ויהי ביום ההוא ויבאו עבדי יצחק ויגדו לו על־אדות הבאר אשר חפרו ויאמרו לו מצאנו מים ויקרא אתה שבעה על־כן שם־העיר באר שבע עד היום הזה
>
> *Then he made for them a feast, and they ate and drank. Early in the morning, they exchanged oaths. Isaac then bade them farewell, and they departed from him in peace. That same day Isaac's servants came and told him about the well they had dug, and said to him, "We have found water!" He named it Shibah; therefore the name of the city is Beer-sheba to this day. (JPS)*
>
> Bereishis 26:30–33

Yitzchak answers the king's request with a feast. Only the next morning, early, do they swear. Look at the order. The meal comes before the oath, as if a treaty needs a night of eating and drinking together before it can be sworn in the morning.

Then comes a small reversal. The king had said, "we sent you away in peace." Now the verse says that Yitzchak sent them away, and "they departed from him in peace." The man who was sent away is now the one who sends his visitors home, and he does it in the same words, in peace. Whatever had been partial in the king's peace, Yitzchak makes whole by giving it back.

On the same day, the servants come with news of water. Rashi explains the name Yitzchak gave the well.

> שבעה. על שם הברית
>
> שבעה *[AND HE CALLED IT] SHIBAH (swearing), in allusion to the Covenant (cf. v.31; "And they swear" etc.). (Rosenbaum–Silbermann)*
>
> Rashi on Bereishis 26:33

The first three wells were named for what happened at them: a quarrel, a hatred, and room. The fourth is named for the oath. Beersheba was already called by that name from Avraham's day; now it is called so again, for a second oath. The city keeps its name "to this day," because two generations swore there.

A question for a later age

On 10 November 2026 an Egyptian court ordered 35 entities and 36 individuals placed on the state terrorist lists for five years. Most of the entities named are Islamic organizations based in Europe. The ruling was reported by *Egypt Today*.

The Torah does not tell us what to make of such a step, and this booklet will not guess at anyone's motives. But Avimelech's visit gives us questions to ask. When a neighbor that once fought Israel acts against movements that also oppose Israel, is that recognition, a shared interest, or neither? Is it closer to the Sforno's king, who came because he saw something true, or to the Ramban's king, who came because he feared a broken promise? Or is it the heron's peace: enough to go in and come out unharmed? The verse allows each reading. What it asks is that we see plainly, as the delegation did, before we decide what we have seen.

From Beersheba to Charan

The covenant is made at Beersheba, and the next parashah opens with Yitzchak's son leaving it.

> ויצא יעקב מבאר שבע וילך חרנה
>
> *Jacob left Beer-sheba, and set out for Haran. (JPS)*
> Bereishis 28:10

The place of oaths becomes a place of departure. Yaakov sets out alone from the town where his grandfather and his father both made treaties, and his first night on the road ends with a dream of a ladder and the same promise his father heard: I am with you. The treaty at Beersheba kept the peace for one generation. The promise of "I am with you" goes with the next.

For the table

1. The Malbim says Gerar thought Yitzchak's blessing was their loss. Where do you think of someone else's success as your loss?
2. The two sides told the story of the expulsion differently, and the Torah did not decide between them. Can you make peace with someone without agreeing on the past?
3. The Chofetz Chaim says a person may be believed about himself but not about his friend. How does that change the way you hear someone's account of a quarrel?
4. When is the heron's peace, entering in peace and leaving in peace, enough?

Glossary

Achuzzas. The companion of Avimelech in Bereishis 26:26. Rashi reads the word as "a band" of companions.

Agent (shaliach). A person appointed to act for another. In halachah, "a person's agent is like himself," within the limits of the appointment.

Aggadah. The non-legal teachings of the Sages: narrative, interpretation and ethical teaching.

Alter Rebbe. Rabbi Schneur Zalman of Liadi (1745–1812), founder of Chabad Chassidus and author of the Tanya.

Avimelech. The title of the kings of Gerar. One Avimelech made a treaty with Avraham (Bereishis 21), and a later one with Yitzchak (Bereishis 26).

Beersheba (Be'er Sheva). The town in the Negev where Avraham and Yitzchak each made a treaty with a king of Gerar. Its name recalls the oath (shevuah) and the seven (sheva) ewes.

Chasidei umos haolam. The pious of the nations. In the Rambam, gentiles who keep the seven Noahide commandments because G-d commanded them; in modern Israel, the title of those who risked their lives to save Jews in the Holocaust.

Chofetz Chaim. Rabbi Yisrael Meir Kagan (1838–1933), and the title of his book on the laws of forbidden speech.

Daf Yomi. The daily study of one folio of the Talmud Bavli, completed in about seven and a half years.

Haftarah. The reading from the Prophets after the Torah reading on Shabbos and festivals.

Hayom Yom. A calendar of daily teachings and customs compiled by the Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, at the request of his father-in-law, the Previous Rebbe.

Kal vachomer. An argument from a lighter case to a weightier one.

Kuntres Acharon. The fourth section of the Tanya, a set of short, technical essays.

Lashon hara. Speech about another person that is negative or harmful, even when true.

Maaser beheimah. The tithe of animals: every tenth newborn animal of the herd or flock, counted under the staff, is holy (Vayikra 27:32).

Mil. A measure of distance used in the Talmud, of about one kilometer.

Mincha. The afternoon prayer, instituted, according to the Gemara, by Yitzchak.

Pichol. The general of Avimelech in Bereishis 21 and 26.

Rechovos. The third of Yitzchak's wells in Gerar, which no one quarreled over (Bereishis 26:22).

Rosh Chodesh. The new month. Rosh Chodesh Kislev 5787 fell on 10–11 November 2026.

Terumah. The portion of produce given to the kohen.

Tzon. Flock; in the laws of tithe, a single category that includes both sheep and goats.

Bibliography

Bibliography

Tanach

Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures. Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1985. English of all verses quoted. Via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026. https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.26.23-29

Miqra according to the Masorah. Hebrew text of all verses quoted. Via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026. https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.26

Commentaries on the Torah and Prophets

Rashi (Rabbi Shlomo Yitzchaki, 1040–1105). Commentary on Bereishis 21:23; 25:30; 26:2, 18, 26, 28–29; and Bamidbar 28:15. *Pentateuch with Rashi's Commentary*, trans. M. Rosenbaum and A. M. Silbermann. London, 1929–1934. Via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026. https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.26.26

Rashi. Commentary on Malachi 1:2–3. *The Complete Tanach with Rashi*, Judaica Press. Via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026. https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Malachi.1.2

Ramban (Rabbi Moshe ben Nachman, 1194–1270). *Commentary on the Torah*, Bereishis 26:24 and 26:29. Trans. Charles B. Chavel. New York: Shilo Publishing House, 1971–1976. Via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026. https://www.sefaria.org/Ramban_on_Genesis.26.29

Sforno (Rabbi Ovadiah Sforno, c. 1475–1550). Commentary on Bereishis 26:24–28. Trans. Eliyahu Munk, *HaChut Hameshulash*. Via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026. https://www.sefaria.org/Sforno_on_Genesis.26.24

Radak (Rabbi David Kimchi, 1160–1235). Commentary on Bereishis 26:27–29. Trans. Eliyahu Munk, *HaChut Hameshulash*. Via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026. https://www.sefaria.org/Radak_on_Genesis.26.27

Or HaChaim (Rabbi Chaim ibn Attar, 1696–1743). Commentary on Bereishis 26:28. Trans. Eliyahu Munk. Via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026. https://www.sefaria.org/Or_HaChaim_on_Genesis.26.28

Malbim (Rabbi Meir Leibush Weiser, 1809–1879). Commentary on Bereishis 26:28. Hebrew as published on Sefaria from Wikisource. Working translation. Via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026. https://www.sefaria.org/Malbim_on_Genesis.26.28

Talmud and Midrash

Bechoros 54a–54b; *Berachos* 26b; *Kesubos* 85a; *Shabbos* 119b; *Chullin* 60b. *The William Davidson Talmud*, English and vocalized Aramaic, Koren Noé edition with commentary by Rabbi Adin Even-Israel Steinsaltz. Via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026. https://www.sefaria.org/Bekhorot.54b

Bereishis Rabbah 64:9, 64:10, 65:1. Hebrew: Midrash Rabbah, TE edition. English: *The Sefaria Midrash Rabbah*, 2022. Via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026. https://www.sefaria.org/Bereshit_Rabbah.64.10

Halachah

Rambam (Rabbi Moshe ben Maimon, 1138–1204). *Mishneh Torah,* Hilchos Sheluchin veShutfin 2–4; Hilchos Maachalos Asuros 1; Hilchos Deos 7:1; Hilchos Melachim 8:11. Hebrew: Torat Emet. English: trans. Eliyahu Touger. Jerusalem: Moznaim, 1986–2007. Via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026. https://www.sefaria.org/Mishneh_Torah,_Agents_and_Partners.3

Kagan, Rabbi Yisrael Meir (the Chofetz Chaim, 1838–1933). *Chofetz Chaim,* Part One, Hilchos Lashon Hara, Principles 7 and 10. English: Silverstein translation. Via Sefaria, opened 11 November 2026. https://www.sefaria.org/Chofetz_Chaim,_Part_One,_The_Prohibition_Against_Lashon_Hara,_Principle_7

History and current events

United States Holocaust Memorial Museum. "Kristallnacht." *Holocaust Encyclopedia*. https://encyclopedia.ushmm.org/content/en/article/kristallnacht , opened 11 November 2026.

Glikman, Eitan. "Israel's last living Righteous Among the Nations dies at 91." *Ynet News*, November 2026. https://www.ynetnews.com/jewish-world/article/b1wn8kwcfx , opened 11 November 2026.

"Last Righteous Among the Nations living in Israel passes away." *Israel National News*, 11 November 2026. https://www.israelnationalnews.com/news/435998 , opened 11 November 2026. (Single source in this booklet for the date of death, the year of recognition, 1989, and the walk of about two kilometers.)

Egypt Today staff. "Egypt designates Council of Muslims of Europe and 35 affiliated entities as terrorist organizations." *Egypt Today*, 10 November 2026. https://www.egypttoday.com/Article/1/150523/Egypt-designates-Council-of-Muslims-of-Europe-and-35-affiliated , opened 11 November 2026. (Single source opened for this booklet.)

Karmel, Ariela. "Eisenkot-led bloc decides to nominate Yashar's Matan Kahana for Knesset speaker." *The Times of Israel*, 10 November 2026. https://www.timesofisrael.com/eisenkot-led-bloc-agrees-to-nominate-yashars-matan-kahan-for-knesset-speaker/ (the swearing-in of the twenty-sixth Knesset on 10 November 2026).

"Ohana says vote to elect new Knesset speaker to be held next Tuesday after majority of MKs demand it." *The Times of Israel* live blog, 10 November 2026. https://www.timesofisrael.com/liveblog_entry/ohana-says-vote-to-elect-new-knesset-speaker-to-be-held-next-tuesday-after-majority-of-mks-demand-it/ (date of the Speaker vote).

Azulay, Moran. "67 MKs move to replace Knesset speaker Ohana, vote set for next Tuesday." *Ynet News*, 10 November 2026. https://www.ynetnews.com/article/skifn0ecfe (date of the Speaker vote).

Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI

All glory to the Ribono shel Olam · Errors are mine

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren